

STATE OF NORTH CAROLINA

COUNTY OF VANCE

The Vance County Board of Commissioners met in regular session on Monday, May 5, 2025 at 6:00 p.m. in the commissioners' conference room, Vance County Administration Building, 122 Young Street, Henderson, NC. Those commissioners present were as follows: Chair Carolyn Faines, Vice-Chair Yolanda J. Feimster, Commissioners R. Dan Brummitt, Charisse Fain, Thomas S. Hester, Jr., Leo Kelly, Jr., and Valencia L. Perry.

Absent: None.

Also present were County Manager C. Renee Perry, Assistant County Manager Jeremy Jones, Finance Director Stephanie Williams, County Attorney Jonathan S. Care, and Clerk to the Board Kelly H. Grissom.

Pastor Abidan Shah, Clearview Baptist Church, gave the invocation.

County Manager C. Renee Perry introduced Mr. Jeff Percy as the county's new facilities and maintenance director. Mr. Percy thanked the board and stated that he looks forward to working with everyone.

Mr. Frankie Nobles, Vance County Employee Engagement Team Chair, was next on the agenda to recognize the new employee of the month. He noted that employees are nominated by their peers, and this month's recognition goes to Delores Woodard with the Finance Office. Her peers noted that she is a team player, is always willing to help others in any way possible, and is always present and on time. Ms. Woodard will receive a monetary gift and a designated parking space for the month. She was presented with a plaque of appreciation, and the board congratulated her on receiving this recognition.

Public comments were heard next. Sharita Jones, Christian Salinas, and Jameel Williams with the Vance County Association of Educators asked the board to consider an increase of the teacher supplement in the upcoming budget as well as an increase for other classified positions.

Ms. Angela Ryan welcomed the new fire chief to Vance County, asked the board to set the fire tax rate at 8.9 cents, supports funding being used for the detention center, and asked the board to vote against the rezoning request that will be addressed under the county manager's report.

Ms. Mary Williams asked the board not to add more burden on taxpayers in the upcoming budget and to find reasonable ways to meet the needs of citizens other than raising taxes. She also suggested placing a cap on percentage increases and to consider lowering the tax rate.

Ms. Caroline Burnette thanked the board for its due diligence in looking into issues facing the community. She asked the board to consider reducing the tax rate in the upcoming budget.

Ms. Sandra Butler Tubbs informed the board that she will be stepping down as the Vance County delegate to the NC Senior Tar Heel Legislature. She introduced Mr. Errol Staine as the new delegate and stated that she will be working with him through the transition. The board thanked Ms. Tubbs for serving in this capacity for the past eight years.

Mr. Peter West, NC Department of Health and Human Services, appeared before the board and provided information on the staffing crisis at the department of social services in child welfare. He noted that child welfare case workers are vital in safeguarding children’s well-being by assessing safety risks, connecting families with resources, and advocating for children’s needs. They are committed to social justice and work to ensure that all children have the opportunity to thrive regardless of their background or circumstances. He highlighted Vance County’s vacancies in child welfare and spoke about ways to recruit and retain case workers through compensation, manageable caseloads, workday flexibility, feedback loops, etc.

Following discussion, it was noted that social worker salaries will be addressed under the county manager’s report.

As advertised, the Board of Commissioners continued sitting as the Board of Equalization and Review to hear from property owners who felt the value of their property was in excess of fair market value. The following appeals were continued from the April meeting:

<u>Name</u>	<u>Property Address</u>
1. Nathan and Elaine Person	1530 South Chavis Road Parcel: 0488 02002
2. Shirley Julian	104 Bowman Lane Parcel: 0595 01031

Nathan and Elaine Person, 1530 South Chavis Road, PIN 0488 02002. Mr. and Mrs. Person were not present. Tax Administrator Jennifer Williams stated that she has not heard back from the Person’s on this matter since the previous meeting. No written information was provided to the board by the tax office.

Shirley Julian, 104 Bowman Lane, PIN 0595 01031. During last month’s meeting, the tax office was directed to remeasure the neighbors’ houses because Ms. Julian stated that her house is smaller, but her taxes are higher. Tax Administrator Jennifer Williams stated that the properties were remeasured and are correct. The neighbors’ houses are smaller. Commissioner R. Dan

Brummitt requested written information be provided to the board on these appeals so the board can make a proper evaluation.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Charisse Fain, vote unanimous, to continue these appeals until supporting data is provided to the board at the next scheduled Board of E&R meeting.

Motion was made by Commissioner Yolanda J. Feimster to allow the Board of Equalization and Review to remain open until July 1, 2025 in order to continue to hear appeals that were submitted by the deadline of May 5, 2025. This motion was seconded by Commissioner Charisse Fain and unanimously approved.

It was noted that Board of E&R meetings will be scheduled as needed before July 1, 2025.

Water District Board

Chair Carolyn Faines called the Water District Board to order.

2010 Phase 1B Signups/Contracts. Special Projects Coordinator Frankie Nobles stated that during the March 17th work session, the board was informed that staff has received several calls from residents who signed up for water in 2010 stating that they no longer want county water. The county attorney recommended that the county ask for a written request from these residents stating that they no longer desire the water tap and would like to receive a refund of their deposit. The board was in favor of this recommendation. Recommendation: Approve or deny for staff to refund the \$125 deposit for those residents that signed up for water in 2010 and no longer want county water.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr., vote unanimous, to authorize staff to refund the \$125 deposit for those residents that signed up for water in 2010 and submit a written request stating that they no longer want county water.

The March 2025 monthly operations report was presented to the board for information. Chair Carolyn Faines adjourned the Water District Board.

Work Session Report

The board held a work session on Monday, April 21, 2025. County Manager C. Renee Perry provided the following report.

Communications Tower. County Manager C. Renee Perry reported that Henderson City Manager Hassan Kingsberry and Assistant City Manager Paylor Spruill discussed the proposed

emergency communications tower to be located at the city's North Henderson Ballfield Park and the request for cost sharing. It was also discussed that Duke Energy may co-locate and cover direct expenses above the grant as well as an inquiry out to Verizon. For FY 2024, Congressman Don Davis' Community Project Funding awarded a grant in the amount of \$2,175,000 based upon a project estimate of \$2,900,000 which included 10% contingency, with the city contributing the necessary land and access easement. The award is therefore 75% of the estimated direct cost. There was discussion on using the current 911 agreement which is 50% City and 50% County to cover the shortfall. City and County staff will begin to work on an agreement and bring back to the board for consideration at a later date. There was also discussion on the current rental property for the current tower. The general discussion was to have staff continue researching the purchase of the property.

Williams Montgomery Park. Ms. Perry stated that Recreation Director Kendrick Vann discussed a PARTF grant that was awarded to the joint City and County Recreation Department to complete a project at Williams Montgomery Park. The grant was awarded in 2022 but due to COVID, the project was put on hold until now. The total project cost is \$1.8 million dollars with a shortfall/match of \$1.1 million dollars. The City/County joint agreement is split 55% City and 45% County for operations and capital projects. The City is seeking the 45% shortfall of an estimated \$495,000 from the County. The Board gave staff direction to check our financial health to determine if it is feasible. She stated that she has not included the shortfall in the FY26 budget and recommended a fund balance appropriation if the board desires to do so. Staff would like to discuss further during the budget work sessions.

EMS Main Station Land Options. Ms. Perry advised that staff sought direction on EMS main station land options. Chair Faines expressed the need to continue to have discussions and keep this matter in front of the board. This matter will be discussed further in closed session.

Sale of Old Aycock Gym. Ms. Perry stated that staff discussed an inquiry about the sale of the old Aycock gym. The board discussed and was not in favor of selling the facility because it is highly utilized by parks and recreation.

\$30 Base Water Fee. Ms. Perry stated that the board discussed several requests to waive the \$30 fee for customers that pay the monthly fee but do not have county water. No action was taken to waive the fees due to contractual agreements with the customers.

Finance Director's Report

Audit Contract for FY 2024-25. Finance Director Stephanie Williams reported that Thompson, Price, Scott, Adams & Co. has presented a contract to continue as the county's auditors for the fiscal year ending June 30, 2025. The fee for the audit will be \$61,500. As approved by the board earlier in the year, staff will send out an RFP for audit services for FY 2025-2026. Recommendation: Approve the contract with Thompson, Price, Scott, Adams, & Co. to perform the annual financial audit for the fiscal year ending June 30, 2025.

Motion was made by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr. to approve the contract with Thompson, Price, Scott, Adams, & Co. to perform the annual financial audit for the fiscal year ending June 30, 2025. This motion was seconded by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr. and unanimously approved.

Assistant County Manager's Report

EMS Week Proclamation. Assistant County Manager Jeremy Jones stated that National EMS Week is an annual event to highlight the dedication of EMS professionals and promote awareness of the critical role of EMS in public health. The week is a time to recognize the vital work of EMS professionals and raise public awareness about the role of EMS in the community. Recommendation: Approve the proclamation recognizing May 18 - 24, 2025 as EMS Week in Vance County.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Charisse Fain, vote unanimous, to approve the following proclamation recognizing May 18 - 24, 2025 as EMS Week in Vance County.

PROCLAMATION
by the
Vance County Board of Commissioners
in recognition of
National EMS Week

WHEREAS, emergency medical services is a vital public service; and

WHEREAS, the members of emergency medical services teams are ready to provide life-saving care to those in need 24 hours a day, seven days a week; and

WHEREAS, access to quality emergency care dramatically improves the survival and recovery rate of those who experience sudden illness or injury; and

WHEREAS, emergency medical services has grown to fill a gap by providing important, out of hospital care, including preventative medicine, follow-up care, and access to telemedicine; and

WHEREAS, the emergency medical services system consists of first responders, emergency medical technicians, paramedics, emergency medical dispatchers, firefighters, police officers, educators, administrators, pre-hospital nurses, emergency nurses, emergency physicians, trained members of the public, and other out of hospital medical care providers; and

WHEREAS, the members of emergency medical services teams, whether career or volunteer, engage in thousands of hours of specialized training and continuing education to enhance their life-saving skills; and

WHEREAS, it is appropriate to recognize the value and the accomplishments of emergency medical services providers by designating Emergency Medical Services Week.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT PROCLAIMED, that the Vance County Board of Commissioners does hereby recognize May 18 - 24, 2025 as Emergency Medical Services Week, and encourages the community to observe this week with appropriate programs, ceremonies and activities.

This, the 5th day of May, 2025.

Carolyn Faines (signed)
Carolyn Faines, Chair

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County Manager's Report

Fireworks Permit - Tourism. County Manager C. Renee Perry reported that Vance County Tourism is requesting approval of a fireworks permit for its annual Independence Day celebration at Kerr Lake. According to Tourism Director Pam Hester, the work will be contracted with a professional pyrotechnics firm which has the appropriate credentials and insurance coverage. Recommendation: Approve the request from Tourism for a permit to discharge fireworks at its annual Independence Day celebration at Kerr Lake on Saturday, July 5, 2025, contingent upon the necessary approvals from the fire marshal.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr., vote unanimous, to approve the request from Tourism for a permit to discharge fireworks at its annual Independence Day celebration at Kerr Lake on Saturday, July 5, 2025, contingent upon the necessary approvals from the fire marshal.

Ambulance Franchise Application - Midwest Medical Transport dba North State Medical Transport. Ms. Perry noted that the board gave the first of two required approvals for Midwest Medical Transport's ambulance franchise during its April meeting. A second approval is necessary in accordance with NC General Statutes. Midwest's application as submitted appears to meet all requirements of the county's ambulance franchise ordinance. Recommendation: Approve and grant ambulance franchise agreement allowing Midwest Medical Transport dba North State Medical Transport, Inc. to provide ALS and BLS service in Vance County in

accordance with the county's ambulance franchise ordinance. Further, to transfer the existing franchise agreement with North State Medical Transport to Midwest Medical Transport.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt to provide ALS and BLS service in Vance County in accordance with the county's ambulance franchise ordinance. Further, to transfer the existing franchise agreement with North State Medical Transport to Midwest Medical Transport. This motion was seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr. and unanimously approved.

Green Rural Redevelopment Organization Nutrition Program (GRRO). Ms. Perry noted that at the March work session, the board expressed concerns with the request from GRRO to partner with the county to provide nutritional meals to those households that are not currently served that may be in need. Since there were concerns from the board, and ultimately GRRO can accomplish this without county partnership, she recommends GRRO moving forward without a partnership/relationship with the county at this time. She stated that if the board thinks otherwise, she will follow its lead. No action was needed at this time.

Lease Extension - Legacy Human Services, Inc. Ms. Perry stated that Legacy Human Services, Inc. (formerly known as Alliance Rehabilitative Care, Inc.) leases the county's facility for the Addiction Recovery Center for Men at 1020 County Home Road. The use of the facility in its current form has existed since 1975. The current lease expires on June 30, 2025 and Legacy is requesting a five-year renewal at \$1 per year. Recommendation: Approve extension of lease agreement with Legacy Human Services, Inc. for the use of the property located at 1020 County Home Road from July 1, 2025 until June 30, 2030, at a rate of \$1 per year, with an option to renew for an additional five years at the same rate.

County Attorney Jonathan S. Care stated that action is not needed on this matter because it is an existing lease and Legacy is exercising its right to renew. This should be treated as a notice to the board with no action.

Veteran Services Grant. Ms. Perry reported that Vance County Veterans Service has been awarded \$18,000 from the NCDMVA Grant Program. The award is made possible by non-recurring funding by the NC General Assembly. She stated that funds must be for allowable costs which provide services to veterans. The period of performance for all expenditures is from March 3, 2025 to July 31, 2025. There is no county match and there is a reimbursement process to

follow per the NC Department of Military and Veteran Affairs Grant Program requirements. No action was needed on this matter.

Rezoning Case #ZMA25-001 (Off NC 39 Hwy S; PIN 0552 01007). Ms. Perry noted that the board tabled the March 10, 2025 rezoning matter to the planning/environmental committee. Since the March 10th regular meeting, the board discussed this matter during its work session and the recommendation is to deny the rezoning request and include the following statement: Pursuant to GS 160D-605, the board of county commissioners, having completed its review of the zoning map amendment recommended by the planning board, finds that the proposal is not consistent with the provisions of the 1996 Vance County Land Use Plan and that the proposal is not reasonable and in the public interest and would permit denser development in an agricultural area.

Motion was made by Commissioner Charisse Fain, seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr., vote unanimous, to deny the rezoning request as follows: Pursuant to GS 160D-605, the board of county commissioners, having completed its review of the zoning map amendment recommended by the planning board, finds that the proposal is not consistent with the provisions of the 1996 Vance County Land Use Plan and that the proposal is not reasonable and in the public interest and would permit denser development in an agricultural area.

Minimum Salary Increase for Social Worker Positions. Ms. Perry noted that this matter is a follow up from the presentation by DHHS earlier tonight. She stated that on behalf of the social services director, she is seeking consideration for an increase in the minimum salary for the entire Social Worker class, including both frontline workers and supervisors. The NC Department of Health and Human Services has expressed serious concern regarding the welfare of children in our county, which is being significantly impacted by ongoing staff vacancies across all levels of the social work team. She stated that competitive compensation is critical to recruit and retain qualified professionals to ensure that essential services and protections for vulnerable children are not compromised. She proposed a one grade increase per the recommendations from the pay study and provided comparative minimum salary data as follows:

Durham County - \$64,093
Wake County - \$54,766
Warren County - \$48,291
Halifax County - \$49,256
Vance County - current \$52,797 proposed to change to \$55,172
Person County - \$57,189
Granville County - \$56,732
Franklin County - \$55,904.00
Nash County - \$56,042.00

She noted that if this board wants to exceed those minimum salaries recommended from the study and increase the social work class by two grades, it will take the new minimum salary for Social Worker IAT's to \$57,654. This would have an additional impact on the FY26 budget. She stated that in the future, she would recommend the board to consider more flexibility in work schedules. Other counties offer telework options, and historically, that has not been an option here. Durham, Wake, and Nash all offer telework options for these positions. Recommendation: Consider and approve moving the entire social work class either one grade or two grades effective immediately.

Motion was made by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr., seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr., vote unanimous, to approve moving the entire social work class up by one grade effective immediately.

Presentation of FY 2025-26 Recommended Budget. Ms. Perry noted that the budget provides sufficient funds to maintain the current level of county services while addressing priorities and goals established by the commissioners for the coming year. She provided the following budget highlights:

- The budget does not include an increase or a decrease in the general fund property tax rate of .7129 per \$100 in value.
- The budget does not include an increase or a decrease to the 7 cents fire tax rate.
- The budget utilizes an approach aimed at minimizing the need for budget amendments by aligning estimates with historical expenditure patterns.
- A total of \$2,361,864 is appropriated from the general fund, fund balance.
- Sales tax revenue continues to be the major source of revenue. Although revenues are projected to increase, a conservative revenue budgeting approach is necessary with today's economic climate. Sales tax revenue is projected to come in at \$12.8M, which is slightly under FY 24-25's \$13M.
- The budget underscores a strong commitment to supporting county employees through competitive pay, recruitment, and retention strategies. It includes full implementation of the compensation study conducted by the Piedmont Triad Regional Council, with a total personnel cost of \$1.1M. Hiring rates have been adjusted using market comparisons with peer counties such as Wake, Durham, Granville, Franklin, and Person, ensuring Vance County remains competitive in attracting and retaining talent. Salaries have been aligned within appropriate ranges based on market data, and for those employees not receiving a market adjustment, a 2% cost-of-living adjustment (COLA) is proposed. Additionally, the study recommends setting a minimum hourly wage of \$15 for all county positions. Failing to offer competitive wages has led to persistent staffing challenges, with the county averaging over 50 vacancies across the last three fiscal years, particularly within public safety and social services. Recent staffing issues in the Sheriff's Office and the Department of Social Services underscore the urgency of addressing compensation disparities; however, these challenges are not limited to those departments. Every part of the organization plays a role in delivering essential services. Investing in fair and competitive compensation is not only equitable, but also essential to operational efficiency. It boosts employee morale, promotes institutional knowledge, and strengthens service continuity. By prioritizing our workforce, we are building a more resilient and effective local government equipped to meet the evolving needs of Vance County.
- The budget prioritizes ongoing and increased costs related to improving community health, meeting educational needs, and training our future workforce. This is achieved through providing a \$50,000 increase for the Granville-Vance Health Department, a \$635,000

increase for Vance County Schools and a \$122,324 increase for Vance-Granville Community College.

Following discussion, motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt to receive the FY 2025-26 proposed budget as presented and schedule the budget hearing for June 2, 2025. This motion was seconded by Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr. and unanimously approved.

The board scheduled two budget work sessions for Monday, May 12 at 4:00 p.m. and Tuesday, May 20 at 4:00 p.m. *Following this meeting, the May 12 work session was cancelled.*

Consent Agenda

Following a few questions from Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt on the tax report and planning report, motion was made by Commissioner Charisse Fain, seconded by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr., vote unanimous, to approve the following consent agenda items as presented: Budget Amendment #40, March 2025 Tax Refunds and Releases, departmental monthly reports, and the minutes of the April 7, 2025 regular meeting, the April 14, 2025 special meeting, the April 21, 2025 work session, and the April 28, 2025 special meeting.

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**Budget Amendment #40
FY 2024-2025
Water Project**

Revenue Amendment Request	Account Number	Revenue Increase (Decrease)
Fund Balance Appropriated	16-399-439900	1,055,673
Total Revenue Increase (Decrease)		\$1,055,673
Expenditure Amendment Request	Account Number	Expense Increase (Decrease)
Contracted Services	16-665-500045	1,049,173
Departmental Supplies	16-665-500033	6,500
Total		\$ 1,055,673

Purpose: Pay Application #4, #5 and for purchasing equipment needed for our water system which includes but not limited to water meters and ERTS.

Authorization: Vance County Board of Commissioners
May 5, 2025

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TAX OFFICE REFUND AND RELEASE REPORT FOR MARCH 2025

TAXPAYER	TAX YR	REAL	PERSONAL	SOLID WASTE FEE	REASON
ALLEN MARTHA BELL	2024	\$805.55	\$0.00	125	CORRECT VALUE
HARTSHORN DAVE	2024	\$0.00	\$35.39	125	PERS PROP BILLED
PERRY LAURA J HEIRS	2024	\$84.10	\$0.00	0	TAXES LOST TO FO
TATUM BRYAN L	2024	\$0.00	\$30.58	0	PERS PROP BILLED

TATUM BRYAN L	2024	\$0.00	\$33.67	0	PERS PROP BILLED
		TOTAL	TOTAL		
		\$889.65	\$99.64		

MONTHLY REPORTS: 911 Emergency Operations, Administrative Ambulance Charge-Offs, Cooperative Extension, EMS, Fire Department, Fire Marshal, Human Resources, Information Technology, Parks and Recreation, Planning and Development, Tax Collections, and Veterans Service.

Miscellaneous

Appointments. The following appointments were presented to the board for consideration:

Library Board of Trustees

Appoint Brooks Spencer to fill vacant position.

Henderson-Vance Recreation Commission

Appoint Suquana Charley to fill vacant position.

Motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr., vote unanimous, to approve the appointments as presented.

At this time, motion was made by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr., seconded by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, vote unanimous, to enter into closed session to discuss a property matter.

Upon return to open session, motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Valencia L. Perry, vote unanimous, to approve the minutes of the April 7, 2025 and April 28, 2025 closed sessions.

As there was no further business, at 8:30 p.m., motion was made by Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt, seconded by Commissioner Leo Kelly, Jr., vote unanimous, that the meeting be adjourned.

Approved and signed June 2, 2025.

Carolyn Faines (signed)
Carolyn Faines, Chair